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AI Cyber Implications from Black Hat 2026

We come away from Black Hat 2026 better appreciating the pace and scale of AI innovation across the industry, though question the shape of near-term demand against expectations for a post-Mythos spend inflection. Ironically, the breathtaking rate of change in underlying technology appears to be weighing on immediate demand as customers take time to evaluate and prioritize pressing needs within their cyber and broader IT stacks. This appears to be compounded by rising component prices as customers accelerate planned hardware refresh activity to get ahead of ongoing price increases. Away from foundational security tooling, AI security has been positioned as the "next act" for a number of the cyber companies within our coverage. Though a potentially lucrative market, our work suggests it is still very nascent and underlying customer demand appears to be "one year behind" the broader vendor narrative (i.e., customers still focused on AI compliance vs agent governance and security). We are ultimately optimistic on the long-term prospects for cyber spending and expect the category to remain prioritized within enterprise tech budgets, though remain more grounded on the likelihood of near-term demand inflection.

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We had the pleasure of speaking with a number of industry veterans across vendors, venture capital, and customers. Reflected in the sheer number of booths on the show floor, cybersecurity is perhaps as noisy as it has ever been, with vendors making a number of competing claims across product architecture, competitive dynamics and talent flow. Two vendors consistently cropped up in our conversations; Palo Alto Networks was praised by multiple competitors within the AI security market for the comprehensiveness of Prisma AIRS, their architectural "right to win" within AI security (given presence at the endpoint and in the network), and their role in defining the market, and we therefore reiterate the stock as our top cyber pick. Cyera was also a hot topic given the importance of data security in securely enabling enterprise AI adoption, and in light of its meteoric rise. Predictably, a number of the public vendors within our coverage were also subjects of conversation, including CRWD, ZS, NTSK, and FTNT. We look forward to engaging with investors in the coming days to discuss our findings in more detail.

Ultimately, though a number of debates persist on the ideal architecture for securing AI agents (especially as it relates to balancing security efficacy with latency), the potential for this market appears almost boundless given the insatiable demand for intelligence. That said, in light of the immense amount of capital that has flowed into the segment (both from larger platforms and venture capital), we can't help but ponder the need for consolidation and draw comparisons with the cloud security segment which has seen pockets of price compression following intense competition.

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Herein, we discuss key takeaways from our time at Black Hat 2026.

- **Rising component costs driving meaningful pull forward** - As investors contemplate the magnitude of current hardware refresh pull forward amidst rising component prices, we spoke with a privately-held network security vendor that is significantly benefiting from customers accelerating planned appliance purchases (achieved 3Q target in <1 month). With hardware prices notably increasing holistically across security, networking, and IT, customers are cognizant of the need to lock in pricing ahead of increases (this vendor's 100GB appliance has tripled in price since December). While still early, the vendor suspects that sustaining growth in 2027 requires significant new business (vs refresh), driven by a mix of new logo acquisition and new product adoption. While perhaps not fully indicative of other vendors, it's a cautionary anecdote as to the extent the current cycle is benefiting HW and HW-attached/adjacent players, perhaps even at the expense of SW-only.
- **Few signs of post-Mythos spend inflection** - The heightened focus on security posture following the Mythos release in April does not appear to have been matched by near-term demand. While we have heard of healthier cyber budgets in the following months, we have concurrently surfaced a number of reasons why this has not translated into inflecting tool demand; (1) Customers are overwhelmed by the pace of innovation and are delaying net new investments to evaluate and prioritize projects; (2) Customers are focusing on refreshing ageing hardware in the midst of rising component prices; (3) Incremental spend is focused on services/implementation vs new tooling, especially at the enterprise level (where much of the key infrastructure is already in place); (4) In some cases, vendor roadmaps have been delayed to focus on hardening their code base. To be clear, we remain optimistic on the long-term trajectory of cyber spending and we reiterate our view that the "Mythos moment" raises the terminal value of the sector, though likely without an immediate inflection (aligned with PANW CEO Nikesh Arora's view, as we recently wrote).
- **Customers still early in their AI security journey** - In recent months, AI security vendors have increasingly shifted their focus from LLM security to addressing the more complex challenges of governing and securing AI agents. That said, our conversations point to customers still being at the earliest stages of their AI security journeys, where we heard suggestions that vendor narratives are "one year ahead" of underlying demand. According to an AI security vendor we spoke with, the majority of customers are still focused on discovering and governing employee use of AI within the corporate network (i.e., shadow AI), and preventing sensitive data leakage (i.e., DSPM, DLP). Demand is expected to shift more meaningfully to AI firewalls/gateways in the next ~6 months, while agent security tooling is expected to only become a broader priority next year. To this point, the vendor noted that their LLM security deals are currently more meaningful than agentic governance deals in quantity and scale.
- **AI agent security requires endpoint AND network context** - Public cyber vendors with roots across network, endpoint, cloud and other control



points have made compelling arguments for their architectural "right to win" outsized share within the nascent AI security market. That said, our fieldwork suggests that native context from the endpoint and the network is required to effectively govern AI agents in runtime; together, they provide visibility into agent intent, tool execution, and downstream interactions across applications, services, and other agents, enabling organizations to monitor and control agent behavior wherever it occurs. Against this context, multiple AI security peers spoke highly of the architectural advantage that PANW holds given their presence in the network and at the endpoint, and the work that they have done to build Prisma AIRS through organic investment and astute M&A (i.e., Protect AI, Koi, Portkey).

- **Balancing security with latency in an agentic world** - The ability to deliver effective security while minimizing latency is arguably even more important in the AI era as agents operate at machine speed and scale. We heard a range of opinions on the acceptable level of latency related to AI security controls which in turn informs broader architectural decisions as vendors build comprehensive agent security platforms. To this point, one vendor stated that "any latency is as good as downtime" and therefore believes that gateways are fundamentally ill-suited to secure agentic traffic, instead preferring a hook-based approach that embeds security controls directly into the agent runtime. Notably, [Uber](#) and [Perplexity](#) utilized similar approaches in their respective open-source AI security architectures. Others emphasized the need to inspect traffic at the source (i.e., distributed inspection and enforcement) vs backhauling traffic to a central enforcement point. Contrastingly, some vendors suggested customers would accept some latency given the benefits of a centralized enforcement point (i.e., deep, contextually-aware traffic inspection). Ultimately, we expect customers to adopt a layered approach to securing AI in its various forms, combining tools built on different architectural foundations to securely enable an AI-driven enterprise.
- **Companies using AI to move faster and drive leverage** - Multiple vendors discussed their usage of agentic AI to drive leverage within their business. We heard of a number of use cases, from code generation to project management agents that collaborate to prioritize features on the roadmap. In general, vendors found agents accelerate the product development process at a similar cost to human developers, allowing mgmt. teams to right-size headcount (one CEO noted they are likely to reduce developer headcount by ~50%).



Appendix 1

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